

Another reason for using the Task Manager is to change the priority of processes. A process with a higher priority, as the name suggests, gets more CPU time. An instance where you might want to decrease the priority of a process is when you're running a program such as Dr. DivX, which is doing some heavy CPU-intensive computation in the background—and you want to do something else at the same time, say use Microsoft Word. You'd then decrease the priority of Dr. DivX so that Word doesn't respond too slowly. And an instance where you might want to increase the priority of a process is when you're running something like Winamp. You don't want songs to skip while you access something else on the hard disk, so you increase the priority of Winamp.

Changing the priority of a process can make it run faster or slower, depending on whether you raise or lower the priority. Remember that increasing the priority of a process increases the chance of system instability.

The **Performance** and **Networking** tabs are for advanced system administration, which in all probability you will not use.

Under the Performance tab are listed the current CPU usage in percentage, a graph showing the CPU usage over time, the page file usage, and the page file usage history. Beneath the graphical view are several details including, for example, how many threads are running, and what percentage of the physical memory is occupied by the system cache.

The Networking tab has the most options. At the default settings, the tab shows you a graph of how much available bandwidth is being used by your network adapter. (This graph shows you the percentage of the total available bandwidth; so if you have a 100 Mbps adapter and your Internet connection is 256 Kbps, you'll see the percentage of the former that is being used, not of the latter.) Beneath the graph are several columns that you can customise. Most of these have to do with bytes and unicasts—how many have been sent and received, and so on.